

Legacy and reputation

In speaking of this great originality and the unorthodox nature of Bruckner's work, musicologist Deryck Cooke, writing in 1980, suggests that, initially, his "processes seemed so strange and unprecedented that they were taken as evidence of sheer incompetence ... [but now] it is recognized that ... Bruckner created a new and monumental type of symphonic organism ...," producing something profoundly different in music, "something elemental and metaphysical."

Although Bruckner's music was sometimes dismissed and ridiculed, it did have wonderful moments of success in his lifetime. His Fourth and Seventh Symphonies, his most lyrical in style, were much acclaimed, and now feature regularly in performances across the world. Much less often played are the monumental, more austere Fifth and often very beautiful Sixth. With their huge structures and exploratory, pre-Modernist harmony, the Eighth and unfinished Ninth Symphonies remain major undertakings. But while the style and scale of a Bruckner symphony is not to every concert-goer's taste, the stature of his achievement is today regarded as unassailable.

"The absolute victory of light over darkness."

HUGO WOLF, COMPOSER, ON A PERFORMANCE OF
BRUCKNER'S EIGHTH SYMPHONY, 1892